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1. AXIOMS FOR A GROUP

To define a group, we begin with a set G equipped with a *composition law*

$$\cdot : G \times G \longrightarrow G, \quad (g, h) \longmapsto g \cdot h,$$

and a distinguished element $e \in G$, called the *identity*. Thus the basic data are written $(G, \cdot, e)$. We often suppress the dot and write gh in place of $g \cdot h$.

Definition 1 (Group). The data $(G, \cdot, e)$ form a *group* if the following three conditions hold.

(1) **Associativity.** For all $g, h, k \in G$,

$$g \cdot (h \cdot k) = (g \cdot h) \cdot k.$$

(2) **Identity.** For every $g \in G$,

$$e \cdot g = g \cdot e = g.$$

(3) **Inverses.** For every $g \in G$, there exists $h \in G$ such that

$$h \cdot g = e \quad \text{and} \quad g \cdot h = e.$$

The first equality says that h is a *left inverse* of g ; the second says that it is a *right inverse*. So inverse really means ‘double sided’ inverse.

Associativity does *not* say that

$$g \cdot h = h \cdot g.$$

An operation satisfying this latter identity for all elements is called *commutative*.

Definition 2 (Abelian group). A group whose operation is commutative is called *abelian*.

It is also useful to observe the following simple result.

Proposition 1 (Uniqueness of inverses). *The element h in axiom (3) is unique.*

Proof. Suppose h_1 and h_2 both satisfy axiom (3) for g . Then

$$h_1 g = h_2 g = e.$$

Multiplying on the right by h_2 and using associativity gives

$$(h_1 g) h_2 = (h_2 g) h_2, \quad \text{hence} \quad h_1 (g h_2) = h_2 (g h_2).$$

Since $g h_2 = e$, it follows that $h_1 = h_2$. We write the unique inverse of g as g^{-1} . □

2. ASSOCIATIVITY, CYCLIC GROUPS, AND ORDER

Associativity allows an unparenthesized product such as

$$g_1 g_2 \cdots g_n$$

to have an unambiguous meaning; it does not allow us to change the order of the factors.

Because of associativity, the expression $g_1 g_2 \cdots g_n$ is unambiguous, regardless of how parentheses are inserted. For $x \in G$ and a positive integer n , we write

$$x^n = \underbrace{x \cdot x \cdots x}_{n \text{ factors}}.$$

If G is finite as a set, its cardinality $|G|$ is also called the *order* of G . If G is infinite, we write $|G| = \infty$ and say that G has infinite order.

3. EXAMPLES

Example 1 (The integers under addition). The triple

$$(\mathbb{Z}, +, 0)$$

is a group. Its composition law is

$$\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z} \longrightarrow \mathbb{Z}, \quad (m, n) \longmapsto m + n.$$

The identity element is 0, and the inverse of m is $-m$.

Example 2 (The integers under multiplication: a non-example). The triple

$$(\mathbb{Z}, \times, 1)$$

is *not* a group, although it is a semigroup. Multiplication is associative and 1 is an identity, so axioms **(1)** and **(2)** hold. Axiom **(3)** fails because most integers do not have multiplicative inverses in $\mathbb{Z}$.

Example 3 (Integers modulo n). Let n be a positive integer. The set of residue classes modulo n is

$$\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z} = \{\bar{0}, \bar{1}, \bar{2}, \dots, \overline{n-1}\}.$$

For example,

$$\bar{0} = \{0, \pm n, \pm 2n, \pm 3n, \dots\},$$

$$\bar{1} = \{1, 1 \pm n, 1 \pm 2n, 1 \pm 3n, \dots\}.$$

Every integer can be written $m = an + r$ with $0 \leq r < n$, and then $\bar{m} = \bar{r}$. Addition is defined by

$$\bar{m} + \bar{\ell} = \overline{m + \ell}.$$

Thus

$$(\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}, +, \bar{0})$$

is a group, called the *cyclic group of order n* .

Definition 3 (Cyclic group). A group G is *cyclic* if there is an element $x \in G$ such that

$$G = \{x^k : k \in \mathbb{Z}\}.$$

In this case, x is called a *generator* of G .

In the preceding examples that are groups, the group operation is both associative and commutative.

Example 4 (The general linear group). The set

$$\mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{R}) = \{A : A \text{ is an invertible } n \times n \text{ matrix with entries in } \mathbb{R}\}$$

is a group under matrix multiplication. Its identity is the identity matrix

$$I_n = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & & 0 \\ & \ddots & \\ 0 & & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Thus the group is written $(\mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{R}), \cdot, I_n)$, and the composition law sends (A, B) to AB .

Example 5 (The permutation group). The permutation group is

$$S_n = \{\text{all permutations of } \{1, 2, \dots, n\}\}.$$

Its group operation is composition of permutations.